

ARTIST ONBOARDING CHECKLIST

2026 Edition • Music Management & Artist Services
South Africa & Pan-African Markets • For Management & Artist Use

This checklist is a structured starting point for every new artist partnership. It covers the full scope of what needs to be gathered, registered, set up, and actioned from day one. Complete each section systematically — incomplete onboarding creates gaps that compound into problems down the line. Both management and the artist should retain a signed copy.

01 ARTIST ASSESSMENT & MARKET POSITIONING

Before doing anything else, assess where the artist genuinely stands. Be honest. Identify gaps early and build a plan to address them with the right collaborators.

CORE ARTISTRY

☐	Vocal ability & range <i>Assess live and studio performance quality — are there gaps that need vocal coaching?</i>
☐	Songwriting & compositional depth <i>Does the artist write their own material? Do they need a co-writer or topliner?</i>
☐	Production & studio literacy <i>Can they communicate their creative vision in a session? Do they understand basic DAW workflow?</i>
☐	Stage presence & live performance <i>Assess energy, movement, crowd engagement — book a performance coach if needed</i>
☐	Entertainment & personality on camera <i>Critical for short-form content — TikTok, Reels, and Shorts are now primary discovery channels</i>
☐	Media confidence <i>Can the artist hold their own in an interview or podcast? Arrange media training if not</i>

BRAND & IDENTITY

☐	Visual identity & branding <i>Is the aesthetic consistent across all platforms? Does it reflect the artist's sonic and cultural identity?</i>
☐	Genre positioning <i>Clearly define the primary genre(s) — Amapiano, Afropop, Hip Hop, Gospel, Afrobeats, R&B, etc.</i>
☐	Target audience profile <i>Define age, geography, listening habits, and platform behaviour — SA vs diaspora vs Pan-African</i>
☐	Role models & reference points <i>Identify who the artist looks up to — use this to benchmark goals and inform strategy</i>
☐	Unique selling point <i>What is this artist's defining difference? Articulate it clearly for pitching and booking</i>

CURRENT MARKET STANDING

☐	Existing fanbase & engagement quality <i>Follower count means nothing without engagement — audit the ratio</i>
☐	Prior releases & streaming history <i>Pull stats from DistroKid/Tunecore/Africor — streams, saves, skip rate, playlist adds</i>

☐	Press & media coverage to date <i>Has the artist had any coverage? From which outlets? Quality matters more than volume</i>
☐	Live performance history <i>How many shows? What sizes? Any notable festivals or headline slots?</i>
☐	Industry relationships already in place <i>Labels, producers, booking agents, publicists — map the existing network</i>

02 DIGITAL INFRASTRUCTURE & PLATFORM SETUP

In 2026, a broken digital infrastructure costs artists real money and discovery opportunities. Audit every platform thoroughly before anything is released.

STREAMING & DISTRIBUTION

☐	Distributor account confirmed <i>e.g. DistroKid, TuneCore, Amuse, Africori, Platoon, or label deal — know exactly where releases live</i>
☐	Spotify for Artists — claimed and verified <i>Check monthly listeners, audience demographics, playlist pitching portal access</i>
☐	Apple Music for Artists — claimed and verified <i>Pull Shazam data, city-level audience breakdown, download trends</i>
☐	Boomplay Artist Dashboard — claimed <i>Priority platform for East and West African reach — essential for continental growth</i>
☐	Audiomack for Artists — claimed <i>Key for diaspora audiences and West Africa. Audiomack Discovery has real organic reach</i>
☐	YouTube Music — artist profile claimed <i>Link to YouTube channel; ensure Official Artist Channel (OAC) status is applied for</i>
☐	Deezer Artist account — verified <i>Strong in Francophone Africa — do not overlook for broader Pan-African footprint</i>
☐	Amazon Music for Artists — claimed <i>Growing relevance in SA as smart speaker adoption increases</i>
☐	TIDAL — artist profile active <i>Worth maintaining for high-fidelity positioning and playlist opportunities</i>

SOCIAL MEDIA PLATFORMS

☐	TikTok — account active, content strategy defined <i>Algorithm-first platform. Short-form video is the #1 discovery driver globally in 2026 — non-negotiable</i>
☐	Instagram — profile optimised <i>Reels are the primary reach driver. Ensure bio, link-in-bio, and story highlights are current</i>
☐	YouTube — channel claimed and optimised <i>Official channel with full back catalogue, Shorts strategy in place, Community tab active</i>
☐	Facebook — page maintained <i>Still relevant in South Africa and across sub-Saharan Africa — do not abandon it</i>
☐	X (Twitter) — active <i>Valuable for industry relationships, media, and real-time cultural commentary</i>
☐	All bio sections current <i>Every platform should reflect correct name, genre, location, links, and bio text</i>
☐	Secure login details saved <i>All usernames, passwords, 2FA backup codes stored securely — not only with the artist</i>

CONTENT ID & MONETISATION

☐	YouTube Content ID claimed via distributor <i>Ensure all releases are claimed — unclaimed content loses revenue daily</i>
☐	TikTok Sound monetisation active <i>Set up via TikTok for Artists or through distributor — viral sounds generate meaningful royalties</i>
☐	Instagram/Facebook Sound Collection active <i>Opt in to Meta's sound collection for Reels — separate revenue stream</i>
☐	Link-in-bio tool configured <i>e.g. Linktree, Koji, or Beacons — all releases, social accounts, and booking info in one link</i>

03 LEGAL, RIGHTS & REGISTRATION

Rights registration is non-negotiable. Unregistered songs lose royalties permanently. Prioritise this section before any new release is distributed.

☐	SAMRO membership — confirmed active <i>South African Music Rights Organisation: samro.org.za. Register all compositions immediately</i>
☐	All existing songs registered with SAMRO <i>Do not wait — register every song regardless of whether it has been released yet</i>
☐	SAMPRA membership — confirmed active <i>South African Master Performers Association: sampra.org.za. Covers neighbouring rights on recordings</i>
☐	All existing recordings registered with SAMPRA <i>Each sound recording must be separately registered to collect neighbouring rights royalties</i>
☐	Management Agreement signed <i>Both parties must have a fully executed copy on file before any business is transacted</i>
☐	Record Label Agreement reviewed (if applicable) <i>Ensure reversion clauses, streaming royalty rates, and term lengths are understood</i>
☐	Publishing Agreement in place (if applicable) <i>Know who administers publishing rights — if self-published, ensure SAMRO reflects this</i>
☐	ISRC codes assigned to all releases <i>Each recording requires a unique ISRC for DSP tracking and royalty collection</i>
☐	UPC/EAN barcodes assigned per release <i>Required for commercial distribution — obtain via distributor or independent</i>
☐	Performer's Protection Act obligations understood <i>Both parties should understand what the Performers' Protection Act 11 of 1967 covers for SA performers</i>
☐	Copyright ownership documented for all works <i>Co-written material must have signed split sheets — do not distribute without these</i>
☐	SARS tax registration in order <i>Ensure the artist's tax affairs are compliant — a SARS issue can derail income processing entirely</i>

04 ASSETS & DOCUMENTS TO COLLECT

Centralise everything in a shared cloud folder (Google Drive or similar) accessible to both management and artist from day one.

ARTIST IDENTITY ASSETS

☐	Artist biography — short (100 words) and long (400 words) <i>Written in third person. Should be fresh, genre-specific, and reflect 2026 positioning</i>
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☐	Professional press photographs <i>Minimum three clean, high-resolution images suitable for editorial use — update at least annually</i>
☐	Artist logo — vector file (AI or SVG) + PNG <i>Must work on both dark and light backgrounds</i>
☐	One Sheet (PDF and editable version) <i>For booking and pitch submissions — see Artist One Sheet template</i>
☐	Electronic Press Kit (EPK) <i>Password-protected link for industry submissions — include bio, stats, photos, videos, and booking info</i>
☐	Award nominations and wins — documented <i>Save all SAMA, Channel O, METRO FM, Crown Gospel, or regional nominations in a single record</i>
☐	Full back catalogue — titles, ISRCs, release dates <i>One master document — the Song Master Metadata sheet covers this</i>
☐	Lyrics — all released and unreleased songs <i>Collected and filed per the Lyric Sheet template — required for PRO registration and sync pitching</i>

VIDEO & MEDIA ASSETS

☐	Official music videos — links and file backups <i>Keep both the online link and a local high-resolution file backup</i>
☐	Live performance footage — curated links <i>Select the strongest two or three for the EPK; label by event and year</i>
☐	Interview and press footage — saved <i>Collect all broadcast and online interview links for the media record</i>
☐	Short-form content archive — TikTok, Reels, Shorts <i>Screenshot and log high-performing content — engagement data informs future strategy</i>
☐	Brand campaign content — saved <i>Any content produced for brand partnerships should be archived for future use</i>

BOOKING & LIVE PERFORMANCE

☐	Technical rider — current and formatted <i>Input list, stage plot, monitor requirements, and backline specification — version dated</i>
☐	Stage plot — visual diagram <i>Must reflect current live setup — share with agent and promoter for every booking</i>
☐	Hospitality rider <i>Catering, dressing room, and accommodation requirements — keep realistic and professional</i>
☐	Performance fee structure — documented <i>Range by event type: club, festival, private, corporate, international</i>

05 FINANCIAL & BUSINESS SETUP

Clean financial administration protects both artist and management. Establish correct structures early.

☐	Artist bank account details on file — dedicated business account <i>Personal accounts should not be used for business income — open a business account immediately</i>
☐	Company or sole proprietor registration status — confirmed <i>If income will regularly exceed R1 million per year, corporatisation is strongly advised</i>
☐	VAT registration — assess if applicable <i>Artists generating over R1 million in taxable turnover per year must register for VAT with SARS</i>
☐	Invoicing capability confirmed

	<i>Artist or management must be able to issue compliant tax invoices for all engagements</i>
☐	Provisional tax obligations communicated <i>Artists are typically provisional taxpayers — ensure 6-monthly IRP6 submissions are diarised</i>
☐	Accountant or bookkeeper engaged <i>Recommended from the outset — financial mismanagement is one of the most common career-ending issues</i>
☐	International payment pathway established <i>For cross-border payments: Wise, Payoneer, or forex-compliant bank account — test before it is urgent</i>
☐	Currency exposure noted for international bookings <i>ZAR volatility against USD, EUR, and GBP must be factored into international fee negotiations</i>

06 CONTENT & RELEASE PREPARATION

Releases require at least 6–8 weeks of preparation to execute properly across all platforms. Build the infrastructure before the music is finished.

☐	Release schedule — 12-month plan drafted <i>Use the Release Plan Template — map out all confirmed and projected releases for the year</i>
☐	DSP pitch deadlines diarised <i>Spotify editorial pitch: 7 days before release. Apple Music: similar. Boomplay and Audiomack: direct relationship required</i>
☐	Song metadata complete for all upcoming releases <i>Artist, title, ISRC, UPC, genre, language, BPM, credits — no blanks. Use the Song Master Metadata template</i>
☐	Content calendar for release cycle built <i>Pre-save campaign, cover art reveal, snippet rollout, behind-the-scenes, release day, post-release push</i>
☐	Cover artwork — final, formatted per DSP spec <i>3000x3000px minimum, RGB, JPEG or PNG, no explicit logos or URLs — check each DSP's exact spec</i>
☐	Playlist seeding strategy mapped <i>Identify target editorial and independent playlists per release. South Africa, Nigeria, Kenya, Ghana at minimum</i>
☐	TikTok and Reels sound strategy confirmed <i>Decide whether to lead with the track hook or an alternative clip moment — brief 3–5 creator partners</i>
☐	Press strategy in place for release <i>Which outlets? Rolling Stone Africa, Okay Africa, TshisaLIVE, The Plug, Channel O, SABC — prioritised</i>
☐	Radio strategy confirmed <i>Commercial stations (Metro FM, 947, 5FM), regional (Ukhozi FM, Umhlobo Wenene, Lesedi FM), independent online stations</i>
☐	DJ and tastemaker seeding plan <i>Who receives the track before release? Documented, with delivery method and follow-up dates</i>

07 TEAM & PERSONNEL RECORDS

A complete, up-to-date personnel record is essential for touring, visas, insurance, and emergency response. Update immediately whenever details change.

ARTIST & BAND MEMBER RECORD

Complete one record per person (artist, band members, touring crew). Store securely — share only with relevant parties.

Full Legal Name	
Stage Name / Alias	

Role	<i>e.g. Vocalist, Keyboardist, FOH Engineer, Tour Manager</i>
South African ID Number	
Passport Number & Expiry	<i>Renew at least 6 months before expiry for visa purposes</i>
Date of Birth	
Residential Address	
Cell Number (Primary)	
Cell Number (Backup)	
Email Address	
Emergency Contact — Name	
Emergency Contact — Number	
Medical Aid Scheme & Number	
Dietary / Health Requirements	
Driver's Licence Number	
Frequent Flyer Programme	<i>e.g. Voyager (SA), BritishAirwaysExec, EtihadGuest</i>
SAMRO Membership Number	
SAMPRA Membership Number	
SARS Tax Reference Number	
Banking Details (Account & Bank)	<i>For payment processing — store encrypted</i>

Industry Team Record

Record details for every professional in the artist's team.

Management Company & Contact Person	
Booking Agent	
Entertainment Lawyer	
Accountant / Tax Practitioner	
Publicist / PR Company	
Radio Plugger	
Digital Marketing Agency	
Record Label Contact	
Music Publisher Contact	
Merchandise Partner	
Insurance Broker	

08 CALENDAR & SCHEDULING

A shared, always-current calendar is one of the most important operational tools in a well-run artist management setup.

☐	Shared calendar established <i>Google Calendar recommended. Management and artist must both have full access — sync to all devices</i>
☐	Entire artist team added to shared calendar <i>Agent, publicist, label rep, tour manager — everyone who needs visibility of commitments</i>
☐	All confirmed bookings loaded immediately <i>Include full event details: date, time, venue, contact, fee, and settlement terms</i>
☐	DSP pitch deadlines added <i>Spotify, Apple, Boomplay, Audiomack, Deezer — pitch windows are strict and non-negotiable</i>
☐	SAMRO quarterly royalty periods diarised <i>Royalty distribution periods must be tracked — late registrations forfeit income</i>
☐	Tax submission deadlines added <i>Provisional tax (IRP6): August and February. Annual ITR12: due date varies — confirm with accountant</i>
☐	Festival and showcase submission deadlines <i>SXSW, AfroNation, Cape Town Jazz Festival, Oppikoppi, One Music Fest — add all deadlines 12 months ahead</i>
☐	Funding application deadlines diarised <i>NAC, DSAC, NFVF, Creative SA — add all application windows annually</i>
☐	Visa application timelines flagged <i>International bookings should trigger a visa review at least 8 weeks before travel</i>
☐	Monthly management review meetings scheduled <i>Set recurring monthly check-in between artist and management — strategy, admin, and finances</i>

09 FIRST 30-DAY PRIORITY ACTIONS

The first month sets the tone. Focus on the foundations that unlock everything else.

☐	Week 1 — Execute management agreement and open shared drive <i>Legal framework and shared workspace before any business is transacted</i>
☐	Week 1 — Audit all existing platform assets and accounts <i>Document every account, follower count, and engagement rate as a baseline</i>
☐	Week 1 — File SAMRO and SAMPRA registrations <i>Do not delay. Every week of delay is a week of uncollectable royalties</i>
☐	Week 2 — Complete personnel records for all team members <i>Emergency contacts, travel documents, banking — complete and stored</i>
☐	Week 2 — Build release calendar for next 6 months <i>Decisions about timing drive everything else — make them early</i>
☐	Week 2 — Confirm distributor and DSP profiles <i>Claimed, verified, and optimised across all relevant platforms</i>
☐	Week 3 — Develop content strategy for next 90 days <i>Platform-specific plan: what posts, what format, what cadence, what narrative</i>
☐	Week 3 — Identify and brief PR and radio contacts <i>Introductions take time — start building relationships before a release is imminent</i>
☐	Week 4 — Review financials and establish payment workflow <i>How income flows, what gets deducted, when the artist gets paid — agreed and documented</i>
☐	Week 4 — First management review meeting <i>Sit down together: review everything completed, agree priorities for the next 60 days</i>

Document Control

Artist Name		Management Company	
Onboarding Date		Completed By	